

NCAA REVENUE, NIL & OUTCOMES

Zach Keller · Expanded Multi-Sport Analysis · github.com/kellerzachary117/ncaa-revenue-analysis

Overview

An expanded follow-on to the original 30-school NCAA Revenue Allocation Analysis: the full population of Power 4 + Pac-12-remnant conference schools, plus 13 non-P5 schools known for prominent basketball or other-sport programs, tested across four sports (football, basketball, volleyball, and a men's-soccer equalizer for schools without football). Tests whether revenue and NIL valuation predict wins and graduation outcomes, and whether the answer differs by sport.

Schools Analyzed: 83 schools, 249 school-sport rows

Full population, not a sample, across the conferences below. "Power 5" is used loosely here: the historical Pac-12 dissolved to a 2-school remnant by 2024-25, and the newly announced Pac-12 doesn't launch until 2026-27, after this project's data window.

Conference	Schools	Tier
Big Ten	18	P5
SEC	16	P5
Big 12	16	P5
ACC (incl. Notre Dame)	18	P5
Pac-12 remnant	2	P5
Big East (non-football)	10	non-P5
West Coast Conference	2	non-P5
Summit League	1	non-P5

Key Findings

- Football revenue predicts lower graduation rates.** Controlling for nothing else, more football revenue significantly predicts a LOWER Graduation Success Rate (coefficient -2.67, $p = 0.004$), the opposite direction from "more resources helps academics," and a different story from the original 30-school project's finding that it's scholarship-investment share, not raw revenue, that drives outcomes.
- Revenue predicts wins, but it depends heavily on the sport.** Basketball ($p < 0.001$) and volleyball ($p = 0.005$) both show real, significant revenue-to-wins relationships. Football's is only marginal ($p = 0.075$); soccer shows none (small sample).
- NIL valuation predicts wins, not grades, and it's concentrated.** Among schools that actually have a player in On3's national NIL 100, a higher NIL valuation significantly predicts a higher win percentage ($p = 0.005$), but has no relationship with graduation rate ($p = 0.584$). Revenue itself strongly predicts whether a school has any NIL-100 presence at all ($p < 0.001$): NIL visibility concentrates at the schools that are already the wealthiest, it doesn't spread opportunity more evenly.
- Real corrections made along the way, not smoothed over.** Three Big East schools assumed "no football" (Butler, Georgetown, Villanova) actually sponsor real FCS programs, confirmed against the source data and corrected before analysis. A circulating NIL "team rankings" dataset turned out to be from November 2023, not current, and was discarded rather than used.

How It Was Built

- Verified the real 2024-25 conference map live (Big Ten, SEC, Big 12, ACC, and a 2-school Pac-12 remnant post-realignment), rather than assuming today's alignment applied retroactively to the data year.
- Pulled real EADA AY2023-24 by-sport revenue, expense, and participant data (the most recent year actually published) for all four sports across all ~2,037 Title IV institutions via the site's live data API, then filtered to the 83-school sample.
- Cross-checked football sponsorship against the actual EADA data rather than assuming from conference membership: caught three non-football-assumed schools that really do sponsor FCS football, and confirmed the true no-football group before picking men's soccer as its equalizer sport.
- Pulled real 2025-26 season win-loss records from NCAA's official stats site and conference standings sources.
- Pulled real NCAA Graduation Success Rate data (2018 entering cohort) for the full 83-school population using the GSR database's conference+sport combined search, rather than one-by-one lookups.

6. Sourced NIL valuation from On3's live NIL 100 rankings (football and basketball only), explicitly restricted in the analysis to schools with real NIL-100 presence rather than treating absence as zero spend.
7. Merged all sources into one school-sport panel and ran the regression models in Python (pandas, statsmodels, robust standard errors).

Languages & Tools

- Python (pandas, statsmodels): data acquisition, merging, and regression modeling
- Git: version control for the full pipeline
- Data sources: US Dept. of Education EADA survey; NCAA Graduation Success Rate database; NCAA official statistics; On3 NIL Valuations

Presenting This

Lead with the sport-specific split, not the pooled average: "more money = more wins" is real in basketball and volleyball but weak in football, and football revenue actually predicts worse academic outcomes. Be upfront that the NIL variable is a real but partial proxy (national top-100 presence), not verified spend; nobody publishes that.